Ellis Marsalis Center: Keeping New Orleans In Tune After The Silence

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This interview was conducted with Lisa Dabney, Executive Director, Ellis Marsalis Center.

In 2005, New Orleans music legends Branford Marsalis and Harry Connick Jr. returned home to their beloved New Orleans to see how to aid in recovery efforts. While visiting, there was a mutual realization that the community needed to rally and come together in order to preserve the cultural fabric of the city. In particular, they wanted to preserve the musical influences, which had been an integral part of this region for centuries. In 2012, the Ellis Marsalis Center for Music opened its doors.

The Ellis Marsalis Center, affectionately known as The Center, is in the heart of the Ninth Ward, providing music enrichment and core programming for New Orleans youth (ages 8 - 18), both after school and during the summer. But that's not all. The city's seasoned musicians have a home at the center as well. Musicians participate in concerts presented by The Center and serve as teachers who assist with the cornerstone youth programs.

Initially, with partners from Habitat for Humanity New Orleans, the concept of Musicians Village came to light. The Village is a residential community of at least 80 homes for displaced musicians who wanted to return home after the storm. The Center became the hub of this community, which was one of the first major rebuild projects after the hurricane. Musicians who typically would depend on local gigs for their livelihood were able to gain employment through budding programs and concerts that became the epicenter of experiences at The Center.

Today, The Center is truly multi-purpose in nature. It has been host to health fairs, food drives, and holiday parties, and often functions as a tech hub with access to the internet for those in the Greater New Orleans area who need it. And yet the focus still remains on music education. The Center is designed to be a safe place where kids are able to thrive and explore their passions for music. With research supporting the value of music education when paired with academics, The Center hopes to foster a spark in New Orleans' youth that will help build confidence and overall become great citizens in the greater society.

Q: How has the grant and partnership from BCM supported The Ellis Marsalis Center's goals over the past year?

Lisa Dabney: The first thing that I want to do is give them a shout-out! The themes of community seem to be really strong in their work. And, I think it is amazing to have a funder in town that has the desire to help support organizations in a meaningful way. Having their partnership has meant a lot to us and our ability to provide support for our students and our music education program. It's not just about the support for communities for BCM, but also about sustaining them. Sometimes funders just write checks, but I think the team at BCM really is a good partner. They go deep with their partners and are one of our funders who is committed to multi-year support. We are just so grateful for their continued support and advocacy.

Q: In the past 20 years, what role has the Ellis Marsalis Center played in the revitalization and the continued recovery of New Orleans?

Dabney: There is true commitment, dedication, and passion to a city that The Center's founders and Board of Directors love. The Center is their way of giving back, but it is deeper than that. It is about pride and a dedication to the cultural fabric of New Orleans. The Center is fully integrated and involved in this community, from the neighbors, to the staff, and the students. And that is a testament to the resilience of New Orleans and its people. The Center and Musicians Village are a love letter to this city. And putting all of this together, you have a tapestry of community and people who just refused to be defeated.

Q: What's your unique origin story about coming to work for the Ellis Marsalis Center?

Dabney: I came to The Center in 2021. I am not a native of New Orleans, but from the East Coast. For me, the answer to this question is wrapped up in why I talked my family into moving from Charleston, South Carolina, at the time. The story of The Center and its impact, and what it hopes to be and what we continue to try and strive to be, was so powerful that it was enough for me to convince my family that this was an opportunity and a community [New Orleans] that was worth being a part of. Like so many Americans, I sat captivated by what was happening in the city during Hurricane Katrina. There is something powerful about using art as a catalyst for social change. And while watching with heartbreak, I was simultaneously so moved by what people like Branford [Marsalis] and Harry [Connick, Jr.] and countless others were doing to help save people and rebuild this community.

Q: When you think about the next 20 years, what role do you see your organization playing in the continued recovery and reimagining of New Orleans?

Dabney: One of the things that we frequently hear, every time someone visits the center for the first time, is: 'Oh my God, I had no idea that this was over here!' I often feel like we are the best-kept secret in New Orleans. We are quietly, steadily, and ambitiously supporting the Ninth Ward, along with the

children, families, and musicians who live in this neighborhood. We want people to know about us. And we have come a long way in the last couple of years, by adding new experiences like our live concert series that helps us attract new audiences. And those people then discover all of the other different things that we do here at the Center. We are an oasis in the Ninth Ward that will continue to expand horizons and provide cultural experiences for every visitor. Our doors are always open, and we want people to come over and enjoy our community!

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Your support makes this work possible. A gift of any size helps Ellis Marsalis Center continue serving the community and building a stronger, more resilient city for everyone.

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